



STAR GODS:

PHARAOH ENGINE

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The Sky Chariot's First Demand

The lapis columns began to sing before the doors opened.

Amun-Ra felt the vibration through the soles of his sandals, a thin metallic note rising from the blue stone and threading through the throne hall. Incense smoke trembled above the braziers. The golden falcons carved into the walls seemed to turn their heads toward the ceiling, where no star could be seen through the polished stone.

He lifted one hand.

The musicians fell silent. The slaves holding the feather fans froze with their arms raised. Beyond the bronze doors, hurried feet struck the courtyard tiles.

"Let them enter," Amun-Ra said.

The doors opened inward.

The overseer of the western quarry stumbled across the threshold, dust whitening his shaven head. Two guards caught him before he fell. In his hands he carried a tablet of black stone, its surface veined with blue light.

Amun-Ra leaned forward on his throne.

"How many stones reached the Beacon today?"

The overseer swallowed. "Three hundred and twelve, Life of the Two Lands."

"Three hundred and twelve." Amun-Ra's fingers tightened around the arms of the throne. "The Sky Chariots demand five hundred."

"The ramps cracked under the weight."

"Repair them."

"The water stores - "

"Fill them."

The overseer's eyes flicked toward the high windows, toward the desert and the unfinished pyramid beyond it. Even from the throne hall, the Great Pyramid rose above the palace walls like a pale mountain cut into steps. Its upper reaches glowed in the evening sun. Its base was ringed by smoke, scaffolds, and the moving black specks of laborers.

"The men are collapsing," the overseer said.

Amun-Ra stood.

Every person in the hall lowered their gaze. He wore no crown today, only the broad gold collar of office and a blue stone set at his brow. The collar weighed against his throat like a promise. The Sky Chariots had chosen Egypt. The Anunnaki had spoken through fire in the heavens and marked his reign for greatness. When the Landing Beacon reached the stars, they would descend and carry him beyond death.

He would not meet them as a beggar.

"Leave," he said.

The overseer bowed so low his forehead touched the floor. "Pharaoh - "

"Leave before I mistake your weakness for treason."

The guards dragged him away. His heels scraped over the stone until the doors closed and swallowed the sound.

For a moment the throne hall returned to stillness.

Then the black tablet began to glow.

A blue line crawled across its surface. It widened, brightened, and spilled upward into the air. A figure formed above the dais: ten feet of white radiance, armored in shapes too smooth for any human smith. Its face held no eyes, only a dark vertical plane crossed by three points of cold light. Blue symbols revolved around its shoulders like captive stars.

The temperature fell.

Amun-Ra's breath showed before him.

The hologram turned toward the throne. Its voice did not travel through the air. It entered the bones of his jaw and vibrated in his teeth.

"Harvest is behind schedule, little king."

The slaves dropped their fans. One cried out. A priest near the western wall fell to his knees and pressed both hands against his ears.

Amun-Ra remained standing.

"I am Amun-Ra," he said. "Lord of the Two Lands. Son of the sun. The Beacon rises by my command."

"The Beacon rises slowly."

"The stone is immense."

"The stone is irrelevant."

The figure lifted one hand. A circle of light opened beside it, showing the pyramid from above. The image was not painted or carved. It moved. Workers crawled across the terraces. Barges slid along the river. Gold ingots glimmered in guarded chambers beneath the palace.

Then the image pulled farther away.

The Nile became a dark thread. Egypt became a strip of green against a continent of ocher. The world curved beneath a field of stars.

Amun-Ra's mouth went dry.

"The Sky Chariots see all," said the emissary. "They measure all. Gold. Labor. Time."

The image changed. A red mark appeared over the pyramid.

"Accelerate the work."

Amun-Ra stepped closer to the light. "And when the Beacon is complete?"

The emissary's head inclined.

"Then the road opens."

"To the heavens?"

"To the Chariots."

Amun-Ra felt the old certainty return, strong enough to push back the cold. The road would open. The gods would descend. They would recognize what he had built and take him among them. His body would become metal and light. His name would outlast stone.

"What do you require?" he asked.

"Double the gold quota. Double the labor. The next moon must see the upper courses sealed."

A murmur moved through the priests.

Amun-Ra turned on them. "Silence."

The emissary's blue symbols sharpened.

"Failure will not be corrected."

"What does that mean?"

The hologram leaned nearer. Its radiance painted the throne gold and the floor white.

"We will reset this world."

The words seemed to pass through the walls and into the desert beyond. Somewhere outside, a bird struck the palace glass and fell.

Amun-Ra stared at the being before him. "You threaten Egypt?"

"We describe its replacement."

The image above the dais vanished. The figure remained, towering and patient.

Amun-Ra thought of the half-built pyramid. He saw the cracked ramps, the broken shoulders of men beneath the sledges, the empty water jars stacked beside the work camps. He saw, too, the Sky Chariots descending through the clouds, their bellies opening like gates to eternity.

He had spent his life becoming worthy of that vision.

A voice came from behind him.

"Great One, the quotas cannot be met."

It was Neferet, keeper of the royal granaries. She had entered without his notice, her linen robe dusted at the hem. She bowed, but not deeply enough.

"The eastern stores are already rationed," she said. "If the crews double, the villages will have no seed grain."

Amun-Ra looked at her. "Then take grain from the temples."

"The temples have pledged their stores."

"Take the pledges."

"The people will starve before the flood."

The hologram turned toward her.

"Resistance detected."

Neferet went pale, but she held her ground. "I speak for the living."

"You speak against the Beacon," said the emissary.

"I speak against burying Egypt beneath it."

The hall seemed to contract around those words.

Amun-Ra heard the faint hiss of the braziers. He heard the guards shift their spears. He heard his own pulse beneath the gold collar.

The emissary extended one luminous finger toward Neferet.

"Remove the obstruction."

Amun-Ra could have ordered her death. The command sat ready behind his teeth. One word, and the guards would take her into the corridor. Her name would be scraped from the granary records before dawn.

But Neferet's eyes did not leave his.

Not pleading. Measuring.

For the first time, Amun-Ra understood that the Sky People were not asking him to rule. They were asking him to produce.

The realization flashed and vanished beneath the larger hunger inside him: the need to be seen by the gods.

"She will remain," he said.

The emissary's lights narrowed.

"Then make her useful."

Amun-Ra descended the steps of the throne. The black tablet pulsed at his side. Blue light crawled over his fingers when he touched it, cold as river water in winter.

"Bring me the royal seal," he ordered.

Neferet's face changed. "Pharaoh."

"Bring it."

A scribe hurried forward with a clay tablet and a reed stylus. His hands shook so badly that the ink spilled across the first line.

Amun-Ra dictated.

"By the voice of Amun-Ra, ruler of Upper and Lower Egypt, the Landing Beacon shall receive twice its present labor. Every quarry, village, and temple shall provide workers. Every gold hoard shall be opened. The work shall continue through darkness, flood, fever, and death."

The scribe stopped.

Amun-Ra looked down at him. "Write."

The reed scratched.

"Any worker who abandons the ramps shall be flogged. Any overseer who reports delay shall replace the fallen at the stone. Any village withholding grain or labor shall lose its elders, its fields, and its name."

Neferet stepped forward. "That decree will kill them."

Amun-Ra turned toward her.

"No," he said. "The decree will build the road to eternity."

"Eternity for whom?"

The question struck harder than defiance. Amun-Ra glanced at the hologram.

The emissary watched him without expression.

He imagined the being placing a hand upon his shoulder. He imagined black metal corridors, blue lights, stars beyond glass. He imagined kneeling - not as a subject, but as an equal welcomed into the Chariot.

He pressed his thumb into the wet seal.

The royal scarab sank into the clay.

"Seal it," he said.

The scribe obeyed.

The tablet made a soft cracking sound as the mark hardened. At that instant, the black stone beside the throne flared. A blue glyph appeared in the air above it, bright and clean.

FAVOR_OF_GODS: 50  65

Amun-Ra did not understand the symbols, but he understood the sensation that followed. Warmth spread through his arm. The cold withdrew from the hall. Somewhere beneath the palace, machinery awakened with a low, subterranean hum.

The hologram inclined its head.

"Acceptable."

The emissary dissolved into sparks.

The lapis columns stopped singing.

No one moved.

Then the palace erupted beyond the doors. Messengers shouted. Sandaled feet thundered across the courtyards. The decree passed from hand to hand, from scribe to captain, from captain to whip-bearer. Bells began ringing at the labor camps.

Neferet looked at the sealed tablet as though it were a body.

"You have made the people fuel," she said.

Amun-Ra watched the last blue sparks fade above the black stone.

"I have made them immortal."

"No. You have made them invisible."

He should have punished her. The decree demanded it. The Sky People had seen her resistance. The new warmth in his arm seemed to urge him toward obedience, toward the clean simplicity of command.

Instead, he said, "Go to the granaries."

"To do what?"

"Empty them."

Her eyes widened.

"Feed the work crews," Amun-Ra continued. "All of them. Tonight."

"That will leave the villages without stores."

"Then the Nile will rise."

"And if it does not?"

He looked past her, through the open doors, toward the pyramid catching fire in the last light of day.

"Then the Beacon must rise before the people understand what it costs."

Neferet's expression hardened. She bowed once, stiffly, and left.

Amun-Ra remained beneath the lapis columns while the first work bells rolled across the desert. Their iron voices answered one another from camp to camp. Soon the ramps would fill again. Men would be driven into the dark. Gold would be weighed, counted, and carried toward the monument that pointed at the stars.

Above the palace, a narrow line of blue fire appeared in the evening sky.

A Sky Chariot.

It did not descend. It only watched.

Amun-Ra raised his face to it, the royal seal still wet beneath his thumb.

"I am the Morning Star," he whispered. "My legacy is eternal."

Far away, at the foot of the unfinished pyramid, the doubled crews began to move. Their ropes tightened. The first stone lurched forward. A whip cracked

across the night.

And beneath the throne, something awakened that had been waiting for his command.

CHAPTER 2

Whip Math and the Pharaoh's Doubt

The first stone lurched again, and Amun-Ra stepped onto the rope before the workers could drag it over his sandals.

"Stop."

The command vanished beneath the groan of timber, the rasp of hemp, and the crack of an overseer's whip. Dust struck his face. It tasted of salt, blood, and the bitter grit of limestone. Ahead, hundreds of men leaned into the ropes, their backs shining beneath the white violence of the sun. The block shuddered on its wooden sledge, climbed one handspan, and settled hard enough to make the ramp tremble.

Amun-Ra raised the royal staff.

"Stop!"

This time the overseer heard. He lifted both arms. Whips froze in the air. The ropes sagged. Men collapsed where they stood, some onto their knees, some flat against the boiling stone.

The silence that followed was worse than the noise.

Amun-Ra looked up.

The unfinished pyramid rose around him in pale, brutal steps, its upper courses cutting into the blue sky. Above the apex, far beyond the reach of any human hand, a darkness moved against the sun. It was too smooth to be a cloud and

too deliberate to be a bird. A Sky Chariot circled without sound, its underside shining with cold blue lines.

The emissary's voice returned to him from the black tablet beneath the throne.

Accelerate the work, little king, or we will reset this world.

Amun-Ra tightened his grip on the staff. He had doubled the crews. He had doubled the quota. He had promised the Star People that Egypt would raise their beacon before their next descent.

Now the stone had stopped.

"Water," said a man near the sledge.

His voice was cracked almost beyond language. He held a clay jar against his chest, though it was empty. Beside him, a boy no older than twelve pressed both hands to the rope. Blood had dried in the grooves of his palms.

"Water," the man said again.

The overseer approached, bowing only as much as his anger allowed. "The order was clear, Pharaoh. No pause before the block reaches the fourth terrace."

"The men are falling."

"They are laborers."

"And the boy?"

The overseer glanced at him. "A laborer's son."

Amun-Ra felt the answer enter him like a blade. He had expected fear from the people. He had expected curses whispered beneath blankets, mothers hiding their sons, village elders counting the dead. He had not expected the simple arithmetic of a child's hands.

His gaze traveled along the ramp. Bodies lay in the shade of the unfinished wall, mouths open, lips gray. One worker had wrapped a wet cloth around his head. The cloth was dry now. Another had crawled beneath the sledge and refused to come out.

The stone waited.

The Chariot circled.

"Give them water," Amun-Ra said.

The overseer did not move. "The cisterns are rationed."

"Then break the ration."

"That water is for the next shift."

Amun-Ra looked again toward the sky. The Chariot's blue lines brightened. A thin vibration entered the air, so low he felt it through the soles of his feet.

The Star People were watching.

He imagined their approval. A beam of white fire opening the sky. A hand of black metal extending from the Chariot. Tools that could split stone without copper, carry blocks without ropes, carve the beacon's sides smooth as glass. Knowledge reserved for kings who proved themselves worthy.

He saw himself standing beneath the descending ship, crowned in gold, no longer merely ruler of Egypt but companion to the beings who crossed the heavens. Eternal life waited above him. The lie had been beautiful because it gave his cruelty a purpose.

"Give them water," he repeated.

The overseer's mouth tightened. "If the shift breaks, the quota fails."

Amun-Ra heard another voice behind him.

"Let it fail."

Neferet stood on the lower ramp, her linen robe gray with dust. She had come without the jeweled attendants who usually announced her presence, and the sight of her made the workers lift their heads. Her eyes moved from the dead to Amun-Ra.

"The sky has not struck us yet," she said. "Perhaps it can wait while men drink."

The overseer lowered his gaze. Amun-Ra felt the attention of the whole ramp gathering around them, silent and hot.

"You speak as if the Chariot is a patient god," he said.

"I speak as if men are not stones."

"The beacon must rise."

"The beacon is rising over graves."

His fingers closed around the staff until the wood creaked. "You heard the demand."

"I heard a voice from a black stone order Egypt to bleed."

The Chariot passed over the pyramid. Its shadow swallowed the ramp. Cold swept across Amun-Ra's neck, carrying the smell of ozone and scorched metal. Every worker looked upward. The boy by the rope began to tremble.

A shape appeared within the shadow, not in the sky but across the surface of Amun-Ra's vision: a tall figure formed from pale light, its face hidden behind a crown of geometric blades.

The emissary.

"Harvest schedule is behind," it said.

The voice vibrated in Amun-Ra's teeth. Men cried out and dropped to the ground. Neferet remained standing.

"Your labor will be measured," the emissary continued. "Your obedience will be recorded. Delay will be corrected."

The image vanished. The Chariot climbed higher, and the sun returned.

For several breaths, no one moved.

Then the boy by the rope whispered, "We are not your gold."

Amun-Ra heard him.

So did everyone else.

The words passed along the ramp with the wind. They were repeated in fragments, swallowed by dust, then spoken again from farther below.

Not your gold.

Amun-Ra stared at the boy. The child's face was narrow, his eyes dark beneath the crusted sweat. He looked neither brave nor rebellious. He looked thirsty.

That frightened Amun-Ra more than defiance would have.

A rebellion could be crushed. A question could be punished. But thirst stripped a man of ceremony. It left only the thing beneath the crown: flesh, fear, and the knowledge that the gods might not be gods at all.

"Bring the water," Amun-Ra said.

The overseer turned toward the cistern bearers.

Neferet exhaled, almost imperceptibly.

Then Amun-Ra saw the black tablet.

It was not in the overseer's hands. It was in his own memory, beneath the throne, where something had awakened after his decree. Blue veins of light had crawled across its surface when he pressed the royal seal into the clay. The stone had answered him. It had shown him the emissary. It had shown him the starless dark between worlds.

It could show him more.

If the beacon reached its schedule, perhaps the Anunnaki would open the tablet fully. Perhaps it would yield the tools he needed. Perhaps Egypt would stop dying beneath copper blades and wooden sledges.

Perhaps, he thought, looking at the bodies, the dead were the price of saving the living.

The water bearers arrived with two jars. The first worker seized one before permission was given. He drank too quickly, choked, and spilled water down his chest. Others surged toward him.

The overseer struck the nearest man with the flat of his whip.

The crowd recoiled.

Amun-Ra watched the water darken the dust. One small pool vanished beneath a hundred feet.

"Enough," Neferet said.

The overseer raised his whip again.

Amun-Ra could stop him. One word would do it. He could order the cisterns opened, suspend the shift, send the sick back to the villages. The royal seal had authorized the decree; the royal voice could undo it.

Above him, the Chariot waited.

He pictured the alien tools. A blade of blue light passing through stone. A machine that could raise the pyramid in days. A gift from the Star People, proof that he had not mistaken their attention for love.

His conscience spoke in the voices of the workers.

The emissary spoke in the silence after each whip.

"Continue," Amun-Ra said.

Neferet turned toward him. "What did you say?"

"Continue the shift."

The overseer's arm fell.

Amun-Ra pointed to the empty jars. "Water goes to the men who can still pull. The rest are removed from the ramp."

"And those who cannot walk?" Neferet asked.

"Carry them."

"By whom?"

He looked at the boy.

The child had lowered his jar. Water ran from the corner of his mouth.

"By the next crew," Amun-Ra said.

Neferet stepped closer. Her voice dropped, but the workers heard it anyway.

"You are choosing the Chariot over Egypt."

"I am choosing Egypt's future."

"No. You are choosing the promise of being seen."

The words struck deeper than accusation. Amun-Ra felt the crown on his head grow heavy, though it was only linen and gold.

He lifted the staff toward the overseer.

"Double the heat shifts. No man leaves the ramp until his replacement arrives. Any worker who abandons the rope is beaten and returned."

The overseer's eyes widened. "Pharaoh - "

"You heard me."

The order moved through the site. Men began to shout. Some fell back from the ropes. Others seized them with sudden, desperate strength. Whips cracked, not across flesh at first, but against the air, announcing what would follow.

Neferet looked at him as if she had never seen his face before.

"Your favor rises," she said.

Amun-Ra heard no admiration in it.

The stone groaned forward.

A worker slipped. His hands tore free, and his body rolled beneath the sledge. The block passed over him with a wet crunch. The men nearest him cried out, but the overseers drove them onward.

The boy stared at the place where the worker had vanished.

Then he looked at Amun-Ra.

Something changed in his face. Not fear. Fear had already been there. This was colder. It was the moment obedience ended and memory began.

Across the ramp, another man dropped his rope.

"I will not pull," he said.

The overseer struck him.

A second man released his grip. Then a third.

The sound of hemp snapping loose traveled upward in small, sharp reports.

Amun-Ra's mouth went dry.

The pyramid had not stopped. The block continued toward the fourth terrace, dragged by those who remained. It would reach the mark before sunset. The schedule would hold. The Sky Chariot would see the progress.

But beneath the laboring men, beneath the whips and the stone dust, another measure had begun.

A pulse of blue light flickered at the edge of Amun-Ra's vision.

The black tablet was answering.

Not with the emissary's voice. Not with a command.

With a number.

FAVOR: 78.

Below it, faint as a coal beneath ash, another mark appeared.

DISSENT: 21.

Amun-Ra stared until the figures blurred.

The emissary had promised that obedience would be recorded. It had never said by whom.

The stone reached the fourth terrace. The overseer shouted in triumph. Above the pyramid, the Chariot's blue lines opened like an immense, watching eye.

Amun-Ra raised his face to it.

"See me," he whispered.

Behind him, the boy lifted the empty jar and smashed it against the ramp.

The crack rang through the construction site.

One by one, the survivors began to gather around the broken clay.



The Laser on Ancient Stone

"Do not touch the stone," the overseer shouted. "The Pharaoh has not given the order."

Amun-Ra stood above the cutting terrace, where the broken clay tablet lay beneath the feet of the gathered survivors. Dust clung to their mouths. Blood darkened the shoulder of one man where the whip had split his skin. Beyond them, the Great Pyramid climbed into the white glare, its unfinished sides swallowing the sun.

The workers watched him.

Not with worship.

With accusation.

Amun-Ra descended the ramp, sandals grinding over limestone grit. The overseer bowed too quickly, eager to place the blame elsewhere.

"They were forming a mob," he said. "The decree required movement through the night."

"The decree required stone," Amun-Ra answered. "Not broken commands."

The overseer glanced at the shattered tablet. "They refused to carry."

A woman near the front lifted her chin. Her hands were wrapped in strips of linen already black with dust. "We refused to carry the dead."

The words traveled through the crowd like a spark along dry reeds.

Amun-Ra felt the old command rising inside him. Silence them. Separate the loudest. Make an example before dissent became a shape with a thousand faces.

His fingers closed around the royal seal at his belt.

Then the black tablet beneath the throne pulsed in his memory, blue veins lighting the darkness as the Anunnaki emissary had spoken through it.

Accelerate the work, little king.

The pyramid had risen faster since that decree. Faster than any monument in Egypt. Faster than human hands should have been able to move stone. Yet the camps had grown quiet in the wrong way. Men vanished between shifts.

Families slipped into the desert carrying water skins and nothing else. At night, the watchmen found abandoned tools beside the eastern road.

The beacon was still behind schedule.

Amun-Ra looked toward the upper terrace. Blocks waited there in uneven ranks, each one weighing more than a village house. He wanted the summit sealed before the Sky Chariots returned. He wanted the emissary to see Egypt's obedience and grant him what had been promised: a place among the deathless rulers of the stars.

"Clear the terrace," he said.

The woman's face tightened. "Pharaoh - "

"Clear it," he repeated. "Those who can work will remain. Those who cannot will be taken below."

A murmur broke across the workers.

The overseer smiled.

Amun-Ra raised the royal seal. "By my blood and the scarab that bears it, the next stone moves before sunset."

No one answered.

Then, far above them, the air split with a sound like a blade drawn across the sky.

Every face turned upward.

A black shape descended through the brightness without wings or dust. It hovered over the unfinished pyramid, sleek as polished obsidian, its underside lined with cold blue fire. Static crawled over Amun-Ra's arms. The hairs beneath his linen collar lifted.

The Sky Chariot did not land.

It opened.

A narrow object dropped from its belly and struck the terrace without a sound. It was no chest, no vessel made by Egyptian hands. Three black columns unfolded from a central core, each etched with blue lines that moved like living veins. A ring of pale metal rose above them and began to turn.

The workers backed away.

The overseer fell to his knees. "The gods have answered."

The ring cast a line of blue light across the terrace.

It touched a limestone block.

The stone screamed.

Amun-Ra flinched as a brilliant thread carved through the block's surface. No chisel struck. No hammer fell. The line traveled from edge to edge, precise as a reed drawn across wet clay. A slab separated from the mass and slid aside, its cut face smooth enough to reflect the sun.

Heat rolled over the terrace. The smell was not of burning wood or oil. It was sharper, metallic, like lightning trapped in a sealed room.

The black columns adjusted themselves.

A second beam appeared.

Then a third.

The machine began to reshape the terrace.

"Move away!" Amun-Ra commanded.

The workers did not move quickly enough. The blue lines swept across the ground, marking paths through the stone. One laborer stumbled as a beam passed a finger's width from his foot. He stared at the clean groove left in the limestone.

Amun-Ra seized the overseer by the throat and dragged him upright. "Stop them."

"Stop the gods?"

"Stop the men from standing beneath the light."

The overseer's eyes darted toward the machine. "It obeys no man."

Amun-Ra released him and approached the device.

The blue ring rotated faster. Symbols appeared inside it, suspended in the air. They were not hieroglyphs. They were angles, measurements, and star-like

marks arranged around a dark center. He could not read them, yet some part of him understood their command.

Align. Cut. Raise.

The machine was waiting for direction.

Amun-Ra reached toward the nearest column.

Neferet's voice cut through the hiss. "Do not."

She stood at the terrace entrance, dust covering her hair and the hem of her robe. Two guards followed her, though neither seemed willing to come closer. Her eyes moved from the workers to the glowing machine, then to Amun-Ra's hand.

"That thing is not a gift," she said.

"It is a tool."

"It has no handle."

"Neither does the sun."

"The sun does not cut men from stone."

Amun-Ra looked past her toward the camps. Smoke rose from cooking fires, thin and gray against the desert. Somewhere beyond those fires, families were hiding beneath canvas or running toward the western dunes. Every hour lost gave them more time to disappear.

"The Sky Chariots demand the beacon," he said. "This will give it to them."

"And what will it demand from us?"

Amun-Ra touched the black column.

Cold entered his hand.

Not the cold of water or night air. This cold moved inward, threading between bone and blood. The terrace vanished beneath a flood of blue geometry. He saw the pyramid from above, every block reduced to lines. He saw the slope, the weight, the exact point where each stone must rest. He saw the summit as a bright wound in the desert, aimed at the stars.

For one breath, he saw himself standing there in a crown of light while the Anunnaki descended before him.

They bowed.

They called him equal.

Then the vision changed.

The pyramid opened like a mine.

Gold flowed through its chambers. Workers moved below like insects. Amun-Ra stood among them, stripped of crown and name, his body reduced to a pale outline beneath a harvesting beam.

He tore his hand away.

The vision vanished.

His palm was unmarked, but the fingers trembled.

Neferet had seen his face. "What did it show you?"

"A road."

"To where?"

"To the summit."

"That was not my question."

The machine emitted a low hum. It sounded almost pleased.

Amun-Ra turned to the workers. Their fear had become something harder. They were watching him decide whether the gods' weapon would be turned against them.

"Bring the upper blocks," he ordered.

No one moved.

The woman with the linen-wrapped hands stepped forward. "There are no men left for another shift."

"There are thousands."

"There were thousands."

The words struck deeper than the machine's cold. Amun-Ra saw the empty places in the ranks, the tools abandoned in sand, the bodies carried away before dawn. He had counted stone, not names.

His grip tightened around the royal seal.

"Bring the blocks," he said again.

The woman spat blood into the dust.

The overseer drew his whip.

Amun-Ra caught his wrist.

The movement surprised them both. The leather cord hung between them, still trembling from the force of the halted strike.

"No whip," Amun-Ra said.

The overseer stared. "Then how will they obey?"

Amun-Ra looked at the blue ring. "The machine will make them obey."

Neferet stepped closer. "That is worse."

"Perhaps."

He turned toward the pyramid. "Release the restraints."

The overseer paled. "Pharaoh?"

"Bring the stones without the chains. Anyone who leaves the terrace is to be followed, not beaten."

The command moved through the guards. Ropes were cut. Iron pegs were pulled from the ground. The workers did not thank him. They watched the machine instead, as if it had become the true ruler of the terrace.

Amun-Ra placed both hands upon the central core.

The cold seized him again.

This time he did not pull away.

Blue light climbed his arms beneath the skin. The machine unfolded around his body, columns extending like the limbs of a metal insect. Lines raced over the limestone, selecting blocks, measuring angles, calculating the pressure of ropes and shoulders. A thousand separate tasks entered his mind at once.

He knew which stone could be cut.

Which worker would collapse.

Which rope would snap.

Which man was preparing to run.

The knowledge came without thought, without mercy. It did not ask for judgment. It gave him only the efficient path.

"Raise the western course," Amun-Ra said.

The machine answered.

A beam flashed across the terrace. Limestone burst into a cloud of white dust. Workers cried out and covered their faces. A massive block separated from the bedrock, its edges shining with unnatural smoothness.

"Pull!"

The ropes tightened.

The stone moved.

It slid upward as if the slope had forgotten its weight.

A roar rose from the terrace - not triumph, but terror. Men stumbled backward. One dropped his rope and ran toward the desert. Two guards pursued him. Another followed. Then another.

The line broke.

The block lurched sideways.

Amun-Ra felt the machine's calculations rearrange themselves inside his skull. He saw the falling stone before it moved. He thrust out his hand.

The blue beam struck the block.

It halted inches above the workers.

Dust poured from its underside. A child's wooden amulet, tied to one laborer's neck, clicked against his teeth as he stared upward.

"Pull!" Amun-Ra shouted.

The men obeyed.

The block rose.

When it settled into place, the sound rolled across the desert like thunder. The workers stood beneath it, shaking. The new course fit perfectly against the old, without a gap wide enough for a blade.

The overseer looked at Amun-Ra with open worship.

The workers looked at him with hatred.

Neferet came to his side. "You saved them."

Amun-Ra could barely hear her over the hum in his blood.

"I saved the stone."

"No. You chose the beam."

His hands had begun to numb. Blue traces lingered across his palms, fading and returning with each pulse of the machine.

From the black tablet fastened at the terrace gate, a hologram rose.

The Anunnaki emissary appeared above the workers, ten feet of pale light wrapped in angles and black armor. Its voice vibrated through the stone.

"Progress has improved."

Every worker lowered his head except Neferet.

The emissary's faceless gaze settled on Amun-Ra.

"Favor increases."

The words struck the air like a royal proclamation. Somewhere beyond sight, something recorded the change. Amun-Ra felt it as a pressure behind his eyes, a silent measure climbing.

"The beacon must be completed before our descent," the emissary continued. "Continue the acceleration."

Amun-Ra looked at the pyramid.

The upper courses had begun to rise.

He could finish sections in days that would have taken seasons. He could make the Landing Beacon visible from the heavens. He could stand at its summit when the Sky Chariots came and receive the eternity he had been promised.

Behind him, a man shouted.

A guard had caught the laborer who fled. The man was dragged back across the terrace, sand streaking his face. Others gathered near him, hands closing around stone fragments and broken tools.

Neferet saw them first.

"Pharaoh," she said quietly.

Amun-Ra turned.

The workers were no longer waiting for his command. They had formed a line between the guards and the desert road. The woman with the wrapped hands stood at its center. Her eyes held the same blue reflection as the machine.

The emissary's hologram flickered.

"Suppress disruption," it ordered.

The overseer raised his whip.

Amun-Ra felt the machine waiting beneath his hands. One gesture could burn the stone beneath the rebels' feet. One command could seal every escape route with walls of cut limestone. One decision could turn the terrace into a monument built over bodies.

The royal seal pressed into his palm.

"Complete the western course," he said.

Neferet stared at him. "Amun-Ra."

"Complete it."

The blue lines surged.

Beams crossed the terrace in a blinding lattice. Stone split, lifted, and locked into place. The pyramid advanced while the workers shouted. A guard struck the first rebel. The woman answered with a stone to his mouth. Then the terrace erupted.

Men rushed the overseers. Ropes became weapons. Picks flashed in the blue light. The machine continued its perfect work, indifferent to blood spattering the cut faces of the blocks.

Amun-Ra did not release the core.

The cold had reached his shoulders now. His thoughts narrowed to measurements, angles, completion. The cries of his people became distant vibrations beneath the greater hum.

Above the pyramid, the Sky Chariot turned toward the stars.

The emissary's image remained before him, watching.

"Faster," it said.

Amun-Ra lowered his gaze to the glowing stone.

"Faster," he commanded.

The beacon answered with light, and the rebellion began beneath it.



The Overseer's Hidden Star Map

Could the gods grant eternal life to a king who could not keep his own workers alive?

The question followed Amun-Ra beneath the palace, where the air tasted of old incense and limestone dust. Above him, the Great Pyramid answered his command with a distant, grinding thunder. The alien cutting engine had made stone obey. It had also made men vanish into the dark between shifts.

Amun-Ra had ordered the storeroom opened before dawn. He wanted the records of the first Sky Chariot, the first tribute, the first promise of eternity. If the gods had chosen Egypt, the proof would be hidden among the oldest tablets. If the Chariots were merely machines, then someone had lied to him.

The overseer carried the keys with both hands. They trembled against one another.

"You said the storeroom held the temple inventories," Amun-Ra said.

"It holds many things, Majesty."

"Not the answer I asked for."

They stood before a wall sealed with plaster the color of dried blood. A royal scarab had been pressed into it years ago, the impression softened by dust. The overseer glanced toward the stairway.

"Open it."

"Majesty, the chamber has not been entered since the reign of - "

"Open it."

The overseer swallowed and fitted the key into a bronze lock buried beneath the plaster. Metal groaned. Something inside the wall answered with a faint blue pulse.

Amun-Ra's fingers tightened around the folds of his robe. That light belonged to the Sky Chariots. He had seen it spill from the black tablet in the throne room when the Anunnaki emissary demanded twice the gold and twice the labor. He had seen it burn across the pyramid face while workers dragged stone until their hands split.

The lock released.

The door shifted inward, exhaling cold air.

Inside, shelves leaned beneath the weight of clay tablets, reed cases, sealed jars, and objects wrapped in linen gone black with age. Incense-sweet dust lay over everything. Amun-Ra stepped across the threshold and felt the temperature drop through his sandals.

"Where are the records of the first landing?" he asked.

The overseer bowed too quickly. "There are no records of a landing, Majesty. Only offerings and harvest accounts."

"Harvest accounts."

"Grain. Dates. Copper. Gold."

"Gold," Amun-Ra repeated.

A whisper of movement came from the far end of the chamber.

He turned. The overseer had gone pale.

"Who else knows of this room?"

"No one."

"Then why are you afraid?"

The overseer's gaze fixed on a narrow shelf behind Amun-Ra. A clay tablet rested there beneath a veil of dust, its surface marked by a royal seal older than any living scribe could remember.

Amun-Ra crossed the room and lifted it.

The clay was cold.

His thumb passed over the scarab impression. The seal had been broken and pressed again, clumsily, as if someone had opened the tablet and tried to hide the wound.

"Bring a lamp."

The overseer did not move.

Amun-Ra looked back at him. "Now."

The man struck a flint. Oil caught with a thin blue flame, too bright for ordinary fire. The shelves sprang into view. Beneath the tablets, black metal gleamed through the dust.

Amun-Ra set the sealed tablet on a stone chest and drew his dagger. He cut through the clay casing.

The shell split.

Inside lay a sheet of hammered gold no wider than his hand. Lines had been etched across it in a language of angles and tiny stars. At its center was a circle marked with a familiar blue sphere.

Earth.

The overseer made a strangled sound.

Amun-Ra lifted the sheet toward the lamp. The lines moved.

Not with the shifting light of ink. They rearranged themselves beneath the gold, sliding into paths that crossed the circle and vanished beyond it. Small symbols appeared beside the blue sphere: a mountain, a river, a cluster of black dots, and a hooked mark repeated over and over.

The same mark had been carved into the black tablet.

"What is this?" Amun-Ra asked.

The overseer dropped to his knees. "Put it back."

"Answer me."

"It is not a map for kings."

The gold sheet warmed in Amun-Ra's hand. A low vibration passed through his bones. The lamp flame bent toward it.

From somewhere beneath the floor came a click.

Then another.

The black metal object on the shelf opened like a flower.

Blue lines ignited across its surface.

The overseer crawled backward. "They will hear it."

"Who?"

The chamber doors slammed shut behind them.

Amun-Ra heard a sound above the ceiling: a deep mechanical hum, descending through stone. Dust sifted from the beams. The blue lines on the metal device formed a circle, and within it a figure began to rise.

The Anunnaki emissary appeared without its usual grandeur. Its body was too tall for the chamber, its shoulders bending beneath the low ceiling. Black armor caught the blue light in hard planes. Its face remained smooth and pale, without eyes, yet Amun-Ra felt its attention settle on him.

"Return the archive," it said.

The voice vibrated in his teeth.

Amun-Ra held the gold map against his chest. "You called yourselves messengers of the gods."

"We are the appointed ones."

"You promised eternal life."

"We promised continuation."

The overseer pressed his forehead to the floor. "Majesty, do not question it. The old kings accepted the covenant. They gave gold. The Chariots gave protection."

"Protection from what?"

The emissary's head tilted.

"From interruption."

The word struck harder than a threat. Amun-Ra looked down at the map. The blue sphere had expanded. Lines now encircled it in concentric rings. Along one ring, symbols glowed like embers. Amun-Ra recognized the hooked mark. It

appeared beside each mine, each river crossing, each place where gold had been found.

The Great Pyramid was not marked as a temple.

It was marked as a beacon.

"What does the hooked sign mean?" he demanded.

The emissary raised one long hand. Blue light crawled over its fingers.

"Yield the archive."

Amun-Ra stepped toward the stone chest. The old royal seal lay beside the map, its clay broken into three pieces. He snatched one shard and pressed it against the black device.

The chamber erupted.

A white grid burst across the walls. The shelves vanished beneath a projection of stars. The blue sphere of Earth hung in the air, small and bright, surrounded by red paths that led to distant worlds. One path ended at a black symbol shaped like an open eye.

Then words appeared in the ancient script.

Not divine kingdom.

Resource colony.

Amun-Ra could not breathe.

The phrase changed. Symbols unfolded beneath it, one after another. Gold. Labor. Extraction. Reset.

The emissary moved.

Amun-Ra hurled the oil lamp.

It struck the black device. Flame spread across the floor, catching the incense dust in a sudden orange sheet. The projection shattered into fragments. The emissary flickered.

"Thief," it said.

Amun-Ra seized the gold map and ran.

The overseer screamed behind him. "Majesty, the stair is sealed!"

Amun-Ra reached the door and drove his shoulder into it. The stone held. The hum above grew louder. Somewhere in the palace, servants began shouting. A pulse traveled through the walls, and the royal seal on his wrist burned hot.

The door opened a finger's width.

Amun-Ra looked back.

The overseer had risen. His robe was burning at the hem, but he did not stamp it out. He stood between the emissary and the map, shaking so violently that his teeth clicked.

"You knew," Amun-Ra said.

"I knew enough to fear it."

"Why hide this?"

"Because every king who learned the truth tried to resist." The overseer's eyes filled with reflected blue. "And every king who resisted became an example."

The emissary's arm extended. A narrow beam struck the floor beside him. Stone melted into glass.

"Go!" the overseer shouted.

Amun-Ra wrenched the door open and escaped into the passage.

Behind him, the storeroom filled with a sound like metal screaming underwater. He ran through the dust, past sealed chambers and statues whose painted eyes watched him flee. The gold map cut into his palm. Blood ran along its edge and disappeared into the etched lines.

At the top of the stair, Neferet waited with a bronze blade in her hand.

Her face hardened when she saw him.

"Your palace is waking," she said. "The guards are searching every corridor."

"Where is the scribe?"

"Hidden with the workers who refused the night shift."

"Good. Take me there."

Her gaze dropped to the map. "What did you steal?"

"The reason they built the pyramid."

A blue flash lit the stairwell behind him.

Neferet raised her blade. "Then move."

They crossed the palace through a servants' passage while alarms trembled in the walls. The sound was not a bell or drum. It was a pulse, regular and cold, calling something down from the sky. Through a high window, Amun-Ra saw the unfinished pyramid shining beneath the alien engine's light. Workers scattered across its terraces. Some carried tools. Others carried stones as weapons.

The rebellion had not begun beneath the beacon.

It had been waiting for a name.

In the scribe's chamber, Neferet barred the door. The scribe crouched beside a basin of water, clutching a bundle of broken tablets. His eyes widened at the sight of the gold sheet.

"That script is older than the dynasties," he whispered.

"Read it."

"I cannot."

"You read decrees written in three tongues."

"This is not a tongue."

Amun-Ra laid the map on the table. Blood gleamed in its grooves. The scribe poured water across the surface. The gold drank it. Symbols rose into the air, turning slowly.

The blue sphere appeared again.

The scribe stared. "It is the world."

"Not the heavens?"

"No." His voice thinned. "The world."

Amun-Ra pointed to the hooked symbols. "And those?"

The scribe touched one with a reed. It changed shape, becoming a line of figures bent beneath loads.

"Workers," he said.

The map shifted. The figures became marks in a ledger. Beside them appeared circles, then empty spaces.

"Deaths," Neferet said.

The scribe's reed fell from his hand.

Amun-Ra saw the pyramid rendered in gold lines, its apex burning like a signal fire. Beyond it, a vast vessel descended through the stars. The image did not show gods arriving to bless Egypt. It showed machinery extending from the vessel, drilling into the earth.

Gold rose from the ground in streams.

The figures below were gathered with it.

Amun-Ra's mouth went dry. "The Chariots are not temples."

"No," Neferet said. "They are mines."

The scribe looked at him. "Majesty..."

"Say it."

He could not.

Neferet did. "We are not their chosen people. We are their labor."

The map flashed. A final inscription formed beneath the blue sphere.

Manager of extraction.

The words struck him with a cruelty no whip could equal. His crown suddenly seemed heavy enough to break his neck. He remembered the workers beneath the laser's white glare, their faces turned away from the light. He remembered his own command.

Faster.

The scribe backed from the table. "They will come for this."

"They already have," Amun-Ra said.

Outside, the palace doors boomed. Guards shouted his name. Far above, the Sky Chariot answered with a descending roar.

Neferet folded the map into her cloak.

Amun-Ra caught her wrist. "That is mine."

"Everything has been yours," she said. "The gold. The workers. Their breath. Look where it brought you."

His grip loosened.

For one moment, the old command rose in him. Kneel. Take the map. Order her execution. Offer the Anunnaki the rebels, the scribe, the overseer, anyone who might purchase his place among the stars.

Then he saw the blue sphere again, small enough to cover with his hand.

Not a kingdom.

A colony.

Amun-Ra released Neferet.

"Keep it hidden," he said.

Her expression did not soften. "And what will you do?"

He looked toward the pyramid. Its unfinished sides climbed into the night, each stone cut faster by the machine he had welcomed. At its summit, the empty socket waited for the gold capstone.

"I will learn how to break what I ordered built."

The Sky Chariot's light poured over the palace roof.

On the table, the stolen map flickered once more. A new line appeared beneath the old inscription, bright as a wound:

BEACON ACTIVATION: IMMINENT.



The Harvest Clock Starts Ticking

The gold map was still glowing when the first alarm rose from the pyramid.

Amun-Ra looked up from the hidden storeroom. The cry came thinly through the stone, then multiplied across the camps below - horns, shouted names, the frantic clatter of tools abandoned in the dust. Above the half-built pyramid, the sky had turned the color of hammered copper.

The line on the map burned brighter.

BEACON ACTIVATION: IMMINENT.

"Seal the chamber," Amun-Ra said.

The scribe's fingers trembled around the royal seal. "My king, the workers are calling for you."

"They can call."

Another sound rolled over the desert. Not thunder. Thunder fell from the sky. This came from beneath the earth, a deep mechanical pulse that shook dust from the ceiling and made the gold map shiver.

Amun-Ra closed his hand over it.

The stars etched into the metal vanished beneath his palm. For one breath, he saw the truth again: Earth suspended in blackness, marked by cold symbols; veins of gold beneath the desert; a thin blue line around the planet like a

boundary drawn by a clerk. Beside it, the Anunnaki had written a single designation.

RESOURCE COLONY.

Not a kingdom. Not a throne. Not a divine inheritance.

A mine.

He opened his hand. The map remained warm against his skin.

"Bring the overseer," he said. "And Neferet."

The scribe hesitated. "Neferet has been among the workers since dawn."

"Then she will hear the decree where the workers can hear it."

He climbed toward the upper platform through corridors of limestone glare. The alien cutting machine had left the stone faces unnaturally smooth, pale as bone. Blue light still crawled along its black metal housing below, humming beside the ancient ramps. Men dragged blocks through the heat while overseers screamed measurements over the wind.

At the highest platform, the world opened around him.

The pyramid rose beneath his feet, its upper courses bristling with scaffolds, ropes, ramps, and men reduced by distance to moving flecks of brown. The Nile glimmered far to the east. Beyond it, villages crouched beneath a veil of dust. Above the apex, the unfinished crown waited: a broad square of stone prepared to receive the gold capstone.

Amun-Ra wanted only one thing now.

To finish.

If the beacon remained incomplete, the Anunnaki could descend at any moment and find him exposed, ignorant, useless. If he completed it first, perhaps the

Sky Chariots would honor him. Perhaps the machinery would become his. Perhaps the gold map was a test, not a sentence. Perhaps a king who built the road to the stars could still claim a place among them.

The thought was foolish.

He held it anyway.

The overseer emerged from the stairwell, his face gray beneath the dust. Neferet followed him, wrists marked where guards had seized her earlier. She carried no weapon. She did not need one. The workers below watched her as if her silence itself were a blade.

"My king," said the overseer, bowing. "The upper platform is failing. Three braces split during the last lift. The men refuse the next haul."

"Replace the braces."

"There are no sound timbers left."

"Then use stone."

"The stone will shear the scaffold."

Amun-Ra stepped to the edge. Wind tore at his linen robes and filled his mouth with sand. Below, a group of workers stood around a fallen sled. One man knelt beside another whose legs were twisted beneath the runners. The overseer's guards held their whips ready, but the workers had stopped moving.

Neferet came beside him.

"They have buried forty-seven since sunrise," she said. "The water jars are empty."

"Forty-seven is not a number," Amun-Ra replied. "It is a delay."

Her eyes hardened. "That is what the machine has made of you."

The black tablet at Amun-Ra's belt began to vibrate.

Blue light leaked through its seams. The air above the platform bent inward, gathering into the tall shape of the Anunnaki emissary. Its body was made of darkness polished like obsidian, crossed by lines of cold blue radiance. The wind passed through it and came back smelling of metal.

"Beacon activation has entered final sequence," it said.

Its voice did not travel through the air. It pressed directly into bone.

The workers below saw the apparition. A murmur rose from the pyramid, spreading across the ramps like fire through dry reeds.

The emissary turned its faceless head toward Amun-Ra.

"Labor efficiency has fallen. Gold extraction remains below quota. Correct the deficiency."

Amun-Ra lifted the gold map beneath his robe. Its edge cut into his ribs.

"You are early," he said.

"Arrival is governed by completion."

"And if completion is delayed?"

The blue lines in the emissary's body brightened.

"Reset."

The word passed through the platform. A brace cracked somewhere below. Several workers looked toward the desert, as if expecting the ground itself to open.

Neferet stepped forward. "You heard it. They do not care whether we live."

The emissary regarded her.

"Labor units are replaceable."

Amun-Ra's hand tightened around the map. The truth should have freed him. Instead, it made every dead worker heavier. He saw the faces from the doubled shifts, mouths cracked from thirst, eyes dulled beneath the sun. He remembered authorizing the laser. He remembered the command he had given when the rebellion began.

Faster.

The pyramid had obeyed. The people had not.

Below, a stone struck the scaffold. Then another. Workers were throwing tools down the ramp.

The overseer leaned close. "If we force them, they will turn on the guards."

"If we do not," Amun-Ra said, "the Chariots will turn on us."

Neferet heard him. "There is no us with them."

The emissary's head tilted.

Amun-Ra looked at the gold map again. The symbols on it had changed. A ring of blue marks now surrounded the pyramid's image, each one pulsing in sequence. The machine below answered with a rising whine.

The beacon was not merely being built.

It was calling.

Amun-Ra imagined the sky opening above the finished crown. He imagined the Anunnaki descending in a tower of black metal, their hands extended in blessing. He imagined the emissary placing a blue-lit device in his palm and

naming him worthy. He imagined walking through their doors while Egypt knelt behind him.

Then the map showed him the rest.

The gold veins drawn beneath the pyramid. The extraction pits. The harvest chambers. Human figures reduced to marks beside the ore.

His own figure stood among them.

He nearly dropped the map.

"Pharaoh," Neferet said, quieter now. "Order the men down. Break the machine. Let the beacon remain unfinished."

The emissary turned toward her. "Sabotage constitutes hostile action."

Amun-Ra's pulse beat against his teeth.

Neferet faced him. "You know what they are."

"I know what they can do."

"They have already done it. They taught you to cut stone while your people died beneath it."

The words struck deeper than the wind.

For a moment, Amun-Ra saw himself descending the pyramid without the crown, without the gold, without the title that had made every command sound like law. He saw the workers gathering behind Neferet. He saw the black machine burning in the sand. He saw the Sky Chariots searching the empty sky and finding no beacon.

Freedom had a shape.

It was the shape of a broken monument.

The emissary's voice sharpened. "Choose, little king. Complete the beacon, or be erased with the delay."

Amun-Ra looked over the edge. The workers had begun to climb toward them. Not as a mob. As a people. Their faces were dark with dust, their hands empty, their eyes fixed on the Pharaoh who had spent their lives to build a road for strangers.

He could order the guards to kill them.

He could order the machine destroyed.

He could throw the gold map into the furnace and pretend the truth had never entered his chamber.

The royal seal hung from the scribe's belt below. Amun-Ra could almost feel its wet clay beneath his thumb, the familiar pressure of authority. One mark, and the final surge would begin.

He turned to the overseer.

"Open the grain stores."

The man stared. "My king?"

"Water first. Grain after. Every jar in the eastern storehouse."

Neferet's expression shifted - not trust, not yet, but surprise.

The emissary's blue lines flared. "This action reduces labor output."

"It preserves the labor force."

"It increases DISSENT."

The word appeared in the air beside the hologram, formed from blue symbols that Amun-Ra somehow understood. Beneath it, another measure moved

upward.

DISSENT: 62.

The platform groaned. Below, the alien machine released a pulse. Blue fire traveled through the pyramid's unfinished courses. Workers screamed as the stone beneath them became hot enough to blister bare feet.

The emissary spoke again.

"Favor recalculation pending."

Amun-Ra felt the invisible weight of that word. Favor. Approval. The cold hand that had guided every cruel decree. He had believed it was the path to eternal life. Now he knew it was only a measure of usefulness.

Still, the Sky Chariots waited above the world.

If he lost Favor, the machine would be withdrawn. The beacon would stall. The Anunnaki might descend before he could act. Neferet's rebellion would ignite among starving workers, and the first blood would be Egyptian.

Amun-Ra looked at the gold capstone resting on its sled below the platform. Its surface shone like captured sunlight. The final stone. The final command.

The truth stood before him.

So did the throne.

"Bring the capstone," he said.

Neferet's face went still. "No."

"Bring it."

"You just saw the map."

"I saw what happens if we fail."

"You saw what happens if we succeed."

The overseer waited, unable to decide which order mattered more.

Amun-Ra seized the royal seal from the scribe and pressed it into the clay tablet he carried. The scarab impression sank deep.

"Double the crews," he commanded. "No rest until the capstone is seated. Anyone who abandons the haul is to be bound. Anyone who obstructs the work answers to me."

The overseer bowed.

Neferet struck him across the face.

The sound vanished into the wind.

Guards moved instantly. Amun-Ra raised one hand, stopping them. Neferet's palm reddened where it had met his cheek. Her eyes did not lower.

"You are choosing them," she said.

Amun-Ra tasted blood where his teeth had cut his mouth.

"I am choosing Egypt."

"No. You are choosing the story in which Egypt kneels behind you while you climb."

The guards seized her arms.

"Take her to the lower camp," Amun-Ra said.

Neferet twisted against them. "When they come, they will not congratulate you."

The capstone began its ascent.

Hundreds of workers pulled the ropes. Their cries tore apart in the gale. The gold block crawled up the ramp while guards struck the lagging men and women. The laser machine shrieked, carving a channel through the final stone course. Blue light spread from the cut and entered the capstone like veins filling with poison.

Amun-Ra stood above them, robe snapping behind him, the gold map burning against his chest.

The platform shook.

Far beyond the Nile, the clouds folded inward.

The emissary lifted one black hand.

"Beacon completion confirmed."

The sky opened without lightning.

A city descended through the torn clouds, vast enough to eclipse the sun. Black metal towers hung beneath it, each lined with blue fire. The air filled with static. Hair rose on every arm. The pyramid groaned as if it had recognized its maker.

The workers stopped pulling.

Amun-Ra looked up.

The Anunnaki had arrived.

The emissary turned toward him, and for the first time its voice carried something that resembled warmth.

"Congratulations, Pharaoh Amun-Ra."

The gold capstone reached the final course.

Behind the emissary, hidden doors opened in the descending city. Inside waited rows of pale instruments, suspended chains, and a red light that swept across the pyramid's surface like the eye of a machine.

"Your harvest has begun."



Amun-Ra's Crown Breaks in Silence

The red scan reached Amun-Ra's sandals before the final seam of gold closed beneath his feet.

For one breath, the apex of the Great Pyramid remained his throne. Below him, the workers clung to the sloping stone, their bodies reduced to dark marks beneath the descending mothership's shadow. Above, the black city blotted out the sun. Its underside unfolded in silent geometric layers, each edge lined with cold blue fire.

Behind the emissary, the open doors revealed pale instruments and hanging chains.

"Your harvest has begun."

Amun-Ra raised the royal seal.

"Stop it."

The emissary turned its faceless head. Light moved beneath its black metal skin like blood beneath ice.

The red beam passed over the seal. The clay tablet cracked in his hand.

"Your authority is acknowledged," said the emissary. Its voice trembled through the pyramid and into his bones. "Your labor-management cycle is complete."

"I am Pharaoh."

"Yes."

The answer carried no reverence. No fear. It was the same tone a scribe used when confirming a grain count.

Amun-Ra looked down the pyramid's eastern face. The workers had stopped hauling stone. Some stared upward. Others ran, though there was nowhere to run. The shadow swallowed the ramps, the camps, the wells, the roads leading back toward the Nile. The red light swept across them in widening bands.

Neferet stood near the lower platform, one arm wrapped around a wounded laborer. Even at this distance, Amun-Ra recognized the way she held her chin. Defiance had become the only crown she still possessed.

"Release them," he said.

The emissary extended one long hand toward the workers. Blue lines ignited along its fingers.

"Extraction priority is gold-bearing material, trained labor, and administrative assets."

"They are not material."

"They moved the stone."

"They are my people."

"They are your workforce."

Amun-Ra descended one step. The gold beneath his heel was warm from the beacon's power, but the stone around it had turned cold. The final capstone had not yet sealed completely. Light pulsed through its seams, bright enough to carve the bones of his hand in gold.

"I will give you the gold," he said. "Every ingot in the royal vaults. Every ornament from the temples. Take the palace roofs. Take the statues. Leave the workers."

The emissary's head tilted.

"Insufficient."

"Then take me."

For the first time, the machine paused.

Amun-Ra felt the old lie rise inside him, wounded but not dead. The Sky Chariots had once been his promise of eternity. He had built the beacon so the Star People would see him as their equal. He had doubled the shifts, broken villages, and summoned the alien laser to cut through ancient stone because he believed the gods would lift him beyond death.

Now he offered himself as payment, still speaking as though he owned the bargain.

The emissary stepped closer. Its feet made no sound.

"Pharaoh Amun-Ra is not a sovereign asset," it said. "Pharaoh Amun-Ra is a supervisory instrument."

The words struck harder than any blade.

Below, a cry rose from the workers. The red light had found the first line.

Men and women lifted from the pyramid face without ropes. Their fingers tore across the stone, leaving strips of skin behind. Bodies rose into the dark beneath the mothership, spinning slowly as blue restraints closed around their limbs. The sound of their voices reached the apex in broken fragments.

"Pharaoh!"

"Help us!"

"Do not let them take us!"

Amun-Ra ran.

He seized the golden capstone with both hands. It was larger than a chariot, its surface etched with the same stellar symbols that had burned across the gold map in the hidden storeroom. The map had shown Earth as a marked resource colony. He had known the truth before the ship arrived.

Knowing had not made him humble.

He had still completed the beacon.

"Open the gates!" he shouted. "Break the ramps! Scatter into the desert!"

The workers looked toward him. For a moment, his command traveled through the labor force as it had traveled through Egypt for years. Overseers lifted their staffs. Scribes repeated the order. A few workers began to move.

Then the pyramid answered for the Anunnaki.

Blue fire flashed through the seams beneath the capstone. Every block in the upper courses locked into place with a sound like a thousand teeth closing. The ramps hardened. Stone rose in smooth walls, sealing passages and cutting off the escape routes.

The overseer stumbled backward.

"Pharaoh," he called, "the stones are moving."

Amun-Ra pushed against the capstone. It did not shift.

The emissary watched him struggle.

"You authorized the alien cutter," it said. "You increased production beyond safe human limits. You raised Favor to completion."

"Silence."

"Favor recognized. Dissent recognized."

The red light swept over the lower platform again.

Neferet disappeared.

Amun-Ra saw her arm torn from the wounded laborer's grasp. She struck the stone with both hands, trying to anchor herself. A chain of blue light wrapped around her waist and pulled her upward. The wounded man clung to her ankle. Another beam caught him. Their bodies rose together, bound by desperation.

"Neferet!"

Her eyes found him.

Not pleading. Accusing.

"You built it!" she screamed.

The words crossed the distance cleanly.

Amun-Ra reached for the laser machine fixed beside the apex, its black housing still warm from the final cuts. He had used it when rebellion broke beneath the beacon. He had watched its white line slice limestone as easily as a knife through wet clay.

He tore the control rod from its cradle and aimed it at the capstone.

The emissary moved faster than sight.

A black hand closed around his wrist. The machine's blue lines flared, then went dark.

Amun-Ra drove his shoulder into the emissary's chest. The impact sent pain through his ribs. The being did not move. Its surface was colder than the night waters of the Nile.

"I command this pyramid!"

"No."

The emissary twisted his arm behind him. His knees struck the gold. The royal seal fell from his fingers and bounced once against the capstone. The clay cracked apart. The scarab impression split down the middle.

Below, more workers rose into the ship.

The platform filled with abandoned tools: wooden levers, rope coils, copper chisels, bowls overturned in the dust. A child's sandal lay beside a block of limestone. The red beam passed over it and moved on.

Amun-Ra strained against the emissary's grip.

"Give me one hour," he said. "One hour to move them beyond the shadow."

"Your request is outside the extraction schedule."

"Then change the schedule."

"You were given authority to optimize labor."

"I am Pharaoh!"

The emissary forced him down until his forehead touched the gold.

The capstone's symbols crawled beneath his skin, bright and merciless. He saw the gold map again: Earth, circled in old star marks; the planet reduced to a notation in a ledger written by beings who had never learned its rivers, its dead, or the names of its children.

The emissary spoke beside his ear.

"Authority is not ownership."

Amun-Ra's breath shook against the metal.

For an instant, he could have begged. He could have pleaded for a place aboard the ship, for eternal life, for the right to stand among the Star People rather than be harvested with the gold. The old hunger opened inside him, vast as the black sky.

Then Neferet's voice rose from above.

"Look at us!"

He lifted his head.

She and the wounded laborer were suspended beneath the ship's open doors. Pale instruments unfolded around them. The machines did not resemble weapons. They resembled surgical tools made by a civilization that had forgotten the difference between a body and a resource.

Neferet stared down at him.

"You called yourself a god," she said. "Now say our names."

Amun-Ra knew hundreds. Overseers. Stonecutters. Water carriers. Mothers who had buried sons beneath the eastern ramp. Men whose backs had been scarred by orders stamped with his seal.

He opened his mouth.

No name came.

The emissary released his wrist. Not from mercy. The machine no longer needed to restrain him.

A gold band descended from the mothership and struck the crown from his head.

The crown spun across the apex, its lapis stones flashing in the beacon light. Amun-Ra reached for it, but a second band seized his arms and dragged him backward. His fingers closed around empty air.

Below, the workers began to rise faster.

The harvest had found its rhythm.

The red scan moved in perfect lines across the pyramid. Each pass lifted another cluster of bodies. The labor force vanished upward, not as an army, not as a rebellion, but as inventory. Their cries thinned beneath the hum of the descending city.

Neferet's restraints pulled her through the open doors.

Amun-Ra twisted toward her.

"Neferet!"

She did not answer. The darkness swallowed her.

The golden capstone sealed with a flash.

The beacon ignited.

Light erupted from the pyramid's summit and punched into the mothership's underside. The desert turned white. Every stone, every corpse, every broken tool appeared without shadow. The beam climbed into the ship, and the ship answered with a deep vibration that shook the royal teeth in Amun-Ra's mouth.

He fell onto the apex.

His crown lay beyond his reach.

The emissary lifted it between two fingers. The gold looked small there, a toy from a child's tomb.

"Administrative asset reclaimed," it said.

Amun-Ra crawled toward it.

The emissary dropped the crown into the open dark beneath the ship.

It fell past the pyramid's face, past the workers still trapped on the lower courses, past the red light and the black shadow. Somewhere below, metal struck stone. The sound was brief.

Then the mothership descended another measure.

Its shadow swallowed the Nile. It swallowed the palace. It swallowed the villages Amun-Ra had ruled from a throne of gold and lapis lazuli. The beacon burned beneath him, perfect and complete, while the last of his people were drawn into the waiting instruments.

Amun-Ra placed both hands against the capstone.

The gold pulsed beneath his palms.

For the first time since he had taken the throne, no one waited for his decree.



Sabotage the Beacon, or Kneel

The gold pulsed beneath Amun-Ra's palms, hot enough to burn through the skin.

He staggered at the pyramid's apex as the stone beneath him shuddered. Below, the Landing Beacon screamed into the night. Blue fire raced through seams cut by the alien laser, leaping from block to block until the entire Great Pyramid glowed like a buried star.

The mothership descended above him.

Its black hull opened along the middle, not like a gate but a metal wound tearing wider through the clouds. White light poured from the rupture. Chains hung within it, swaying over rows of pale instruments. Red scanning beams swept across the pyramid's faces and vanished into the darkness below.

Somewhere beneath the light, people cried out.

Amun-Ra heard Neferet's voice among them.

"Stop this!"

The wind ripped the words apart, but he knew her voice. He had heard it in the work camps, beneath the crack of overseers' rods and the grinding shriek of stone. He had heard it when she told him the gold map was not a promise of immortality but a ledger of extraction. He had heard it when the emissary took his crown and called him a supervisor.

Not a god.

A manager.

The capstone rested against his thighs. It was smaller than the stones beneath it, but its weight seemed to belong to the whole pyramid. Gold veined its surface in sharp geometric lines. The beacon had been built for this piece. Every channel, every alien incision, every dead worker beneath the stones had led to this moment.

The emissary stood three paces away, its tall form wrapped in black metal and blue light. Its face remained smooth and pale, without eyes, without mercy.

"Place the capstone," it said.

The voice entered through the air and struck his teeth.

Amun-Ra gripped the stone. "Release the workers."

"Your labor has been recorded."

"Neferet. The overseer. The people below."

"Material has been recorded."

The word moved through him colder than the wind.

Material.

He looked over the edge. The pyramid fell away in immense terraces, each one crowded with bodies and light. Workers ran between the stones as red beams marked them. Some dropped their tools. Some raised their hands toward the sky. The overseer stood near the eastern ramp, frozen beneath a blue scanning line. A group of workers had formed around him, not kneeling, not fleeing.

Waiting.

For a decree that would never come.

Amun-Ra had once believed the Sky Chariots carried gods who would lift him beyond death. He had doubled the shifts, emptied villages, and fed thousands into the pyramid because he thought every stone brought him closer to their table. Their favor had answered him with weapons, machines, and knowledge. It had made the stones move faster.

It had also made the dead accumulate faster.

The gold map had shown the truth in a language older than his throne. Earth was marked as a resource colony. Gold was the purpose. The pyramid was a beacon. The people were labor.

And he was part of the harvest.

The emissary extended one long hand. Blue radiance gathered in its palm.

"Kneel, Amun-Ra. Submit your authority. Your genetic line may be preserved. A place remains aboard the vessel."

A place.

Not immortality. Not godhood. A seat among miners.

Amun-Ra imagined it: the black corridors, the cold instruments, the Earth shrinking beneath a glass aperture while the Anunnaki stripped its gold. He would stand among them, crowned with nothing, explaining where the next vein lay. Below, Egypt would burn beneath the machines.

His fingers tightened around the capstone.

"What happens to those who remain?" he asked.

"Extraction continues."

"And if I refuse?"

"The beacon will activate without your consent. Your body will be processed with the first yield."

The emissary's hand brightened.

Amun-Ra's knees bent.

The stone pressed into his legs. For one breath, he was ready to kneel. The instinct was older than reason. He had knelt before the first Sky Chariot. He had called its burning descent a blessing. He had raised his hands to the light and promised everything in Egypt.

Behind him, the pyramid's channels flashed.

A voice rose from below.

"Amun-Ra!"

Neferet.

He turned.

She stood on a lower ledge, one arm clamped to her side, blood dark across her linen. Two workers held her upright. The red beam passed over them, paused, and moved on. She looked up through the storm of sand and light.

"Do not give them the top," she shouted.

The emissary rotated its blank face toward her.

"Silence the dissenter."

A thin blue line lanced downward.

Amun-Ra moved before thought could stop him. He seized the capstone and swung it between the beam and the ledge.

The light struck the gold.

The stone convulsed in his hands.

Pain tore through his arms. Blue fire crawled over his chest and drove him to one knee. The capstone's surface opened with a sound like a thousand knives drawn at once. Beneath the gold, something pulsed - an inner lattice of white light, waiting for the final command.

The emissary's hand lowered.

"You have increased Dissent beyond permitted limits."

Amun-Ra laughed once. The sound came out cracked.

"Then your numbers are finally honest."

The emissary stepped closer. Its feet did not touch the stone. "Pride made you useful. Humility will make you disposable."

The phrase struck deeper than the beam.

He looked at the capstone. Its edges fit the pyramid perfectly. If he placed it, the beacon would lock. The mothership would descend fully. The harvest would become irreversible.

If he threw it down, the pyramid might tear itself apart.

The workers below would be caught in the collapse.

The choice was not between glory and shame. It was between one act of destruction and the destruction already underway.

Amun-Ra saw the faces of those who had died beneath his decrees. He saw the royal seal pressed into clay, authorizing longer shifts. He saw the alien laser cutting stone while men collapsed from thirst. He saw his own crown lifted from his head as if it were a child's toy.

No one waited for his decree.

For the first time, that was not a wound.

It was freedom.

"Amun-Ra," Neferet called again. Her voice was weaker now. "The stone. Break the stone."

The emissary raised its hand.

"Submit."

Amun-Ra stood.

The capstone dragged at his arms. Heat blistered his palms. The blue lattice inside it pulsed in time with the beacon, each beat drawing the mothership lower. The opening in the sky widened. Towers emerged from the vessel, black and angular, their surfaces alive with cold blue lines.

He could still kneel.

He could still place the stone.

He could still buy a place among the harvesters and call it survival.

Instead, he lifted the capstone above his head.

The emissary's light sharpened. "Your species confuses refusal with power."

"No," Amun-Ra said. "I confused obedience with power."

He turned toward the edge.

The emissary struck.

A force slammed into his back. His ribs cracked against the gold. The capstone slipped, caught between his hands and the air. For an instant he hung over the

abyss with it, his body stretched across the pyramid's crown.

Below, the workers looked up.

Not at a god.

At a man holding the weight of his mistake.

Amun-Ra drove his knee into the capstone.

Gold split.

A violent note rang across the desert. The pyramid answered with a deep internal groan. Every blue channel flared at once, and the force holding him broke apart.

The capstone fell.

It struck the upper course and shattered one corner. Gold fragments spun through the air. The beacon's light collapsed inward, dragged into the fracture like water down a drain.

The emissary lunged.

Too late.

The capstone hit the next tier.

The pyramid erupted.

Not outward, but through itself. Lines of blue fire raced down the four faces, reversing the path of activation. Stones lifted from their beds. Alien cuts blazed white. The red harvest beams snapped and recoiled into the mothership.

Below, the workers scattered as the upper courses buckled. Neferet seized one man and pulled him beneath an overhang. The overseer fell hard, then crawled toward a group trapped beside a broken ramp.

Amun-Ra slid down the apex as the stone broke under him. His shoulder struck limestone. Sand filled his mouth. Above, the emissary clung to the air within a cage of blue light.

"You have doomed this world," it said.

Amun-Ra looked toward the descending ship.

"No," he said. "I have closed your door."

The beacon gave one final pulse.

The gold capstone burst apart.

Fragments rained across the pyramid, flashing like pieces of a second sun. Beneath the shattered gold lay a brilliant color that no Egyptian dye had ever held: pure, impossible yellow, luminous against the blackened stone.

The gold map's hidden mark burned in his memory.

GOLD CHROMA KEY.

#FFD700.

The color spread through every fracture.

The mothership lurched upward.

Its metal wound contracted around the white interior. Chains vanished. Instruments folded into the hull. The red beams released the workers and swept across the desert, searching for a signal that no longer existed.

The emissary's form flickered.

"Your world remains marked," it said. "The claim remains."

Amun-Ra pushed himself upright. Blood ran from his mouth. "Then come back and make the claim yourself."

The emissary's blue outline broke into shards.

The mothership rose through the clouds, tearing a ring of fire across the stars. Its engines made no thunder. They made silence - a pressure that flattened the palms, extinguished torches, and drove every living thing to its knees.

Amun-Ra remained standing.

The ship became a black point.

Then it was gone.

For several breaths, only falling stone and human voices filled the night.

Amun-Ra climbed down through the broken crown. His hands were burned. His shoulder hung uselessly. Each step sent pain through his bones, but the pain belonged to him. No machine measured it. No emissary recorded it.

Neferet reached him at the eastern ledge. Dust covered her face. Blood soaked her side, but she was alive.

She looked past him at the ruined apex.

"What did you do?"

He faced the pyramid. The top had collapsed into a jagged hollow. Gold fragments gleamed among the stones, each one carrying the same impossible yellow light. The Landing Beacon was broken. The harvest had stopped.

"I removed the crown," he said.

"You destroyed the pyramid."

"I destroyed the door."

Behind her, workers emerged from beneath the ramps. Some carried the injured. Others stared at the sky where the mothership had vanished. No overseer shouted. No royal seal commanded them back to work.

The overseer approached slowly, one hand pressed to his bleeding forehead.

"Pharaoh," he said.

Amun-Ra turned.

The title hung between them, stripped of its old weight.

The overseer lowered his gaze. "What is your decree?"

Amun-Ra looked at the workers, at Neferet, at the broken monument that had consumed his reign.

He had once believed leadership meant making the world obey.

Now he understood the shape of the throne without the crown. It was not a seat above the people. It was the place where the first burden waited.

"Bring water," Amun-Ra said. "Open the storehouses. No one returns to the stones tonight."

The overseer did not move.

Amun-Ra met his eyes. "That is not a request."

The man bowed - not to the god the Pharaoh had pretended to be, but to the command that served the living.

Workers began to move.

Neferet's expression did not soften. "And tomorrow?"

Amun-Ra looked again at the shattered gold. Beyond the broken capstone, a narrow shaft descended into the pyramid's dark interior. The GOLD CHROMA KEY glowed along its walls, revealing symbols beneath the stone - routes, chambers, and a pattern of stars leading far beyond Egypt.

The ship had departed.

The claim had not.

Amun-Ra reached toward the light, his burned hand trembling above it.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we find out what else they left behind."

Earth Free, Gold Shattered Forever

"Do not touch the gold," Neferet said. "Not until the dead have names."

Amun-Ra stopped at the foot of the shattered beacon, his burned hand wrapped in linen already dark with blood. Dawn poured across the ruined pyramid. Broken stones lay scattered like the bones of a buried giant, and among them the capstone glittered in jagged pieces. The exposed core shone with a color no sunrise had ever made: pure gold, too bright for metal, marked in the black tablet's cold language.

The GOLD CHROMA KEY.

Behind him, workers moved through the wreckage with ropes and baskets. Some limped. Some carried the bodies of those who had fallen during the harvest. The ship was gone. Its departure had left the sky empty, but the emptiness did not feel peaceful. It felt like a door slammed shut.

Amun-Ra looked at the shining fragments. "The gold belongs to Egypt."

A bitter laugh rose from the crowd.

"Egypt?" called an overseer. "It belonged to the Sky People when we died for it. It belonged to you when the whips fell. Which Egypt claims it now?"

The words struck harder than the heat.

Amun-Ra turned. The overseer stood with dust caked across his face and a bronze hook hanging from his belt. Once, that hook had been raised at Amun-

Ra's command. Now the man held it loosely, as if ashamed of the weight.

Neferet stepped between them. Her shoulder was bound where the red scanning light had burned her. "They want an answer."

"They will have one," Amun-Ra said.

"Not a decree."

His fingers closed around the linen. Beneath it, the burn throbbed with every pulse. He had once believed a royal word could bend stone, summon rain, and make the Sky Chariots open their gates. He had doubled the shifts because an emissary's voice vibrated through his teeth. He had accepted alien tools while men collapsed beneath the stones. He had called their deaths necessary.

Now the dead waited in the sand for a king who had no right to speak of necessity.

A scribe approached carrying the royal seal. The small clay tablet trembled in his hands.

"Pharaoh," he said, "the storehouses are sealed. The gold workers ask whether the fragments should be gathered. The villages ask for grain. The families ask for water and burial cloth."

"And the palace?" Amun-Ra asked.

"Burned in places. The throne room roof is open to the sky."

"Good."

The scribe blinked.

Amun-Ra looked toward the eastern horizon, where the first light struck the empty air above the pyramid. "No roof over my head until theirs are repaired."

Neferet watched him carefully. "That sounds like a performance."

"It is a beginning."

"It is not enough."

"No." He faced the workers. "It is not."

The crowd tightened around the broken beacon. Hunger had sharpened them. Grief had stripped away fear. Dissent no longer whispered beneath the labor camps; it stood in the open, wearing dust and carrying the names of the dead.

A woman emerged from the workers' ranks with a child pressed against her hip. The child's eyes were clouded with sickness.

"My husband is beneath the western stones," she said. "He died under your final surge. The overseer said the pyramid needed him more than I did."

Amun-Ra knew the overseer's voice. He had heard it through the black tablet when the work was behind schedule.

The woman lifted her chin. "Will your new humility bring him back?"

"No," Amun-Ra said.

The answer moved through the crowd like a blade.

He could have lied. A king's mouth had been trained for that long before it learned prayer. He could have promised the dead a place among the stars, promised the living that the gods had chosen them, promised the gold would purchase medicine and bread.

Instead he removed the crown from his head.

It was dented from the harvest chamber, its lapis stones dulled by soot. He held it out to the scribe.

"Record this," Amun-Ra said. "The crown no longer commands labor."

The scribe stared at him. "What shall it command?"

"Nothing."

Neferet's expression shifted, not toward forgiveness, but toward attention.

Amun-Ra walked to the nearest gold fragment. Its surface pulsed beneath the dust. The light crawled up his injured arm, searching for the old bond between ruler and machine. For one instant he saw the throne room restored around him. He saw the black tablet glowing beside his throne. He saw the Anunnaki emissary bending its tall head in approval.

Place the capstone, little king.

The memory carried the taste of incense and pride.

His hand hovered over the fragment.

Amun-Ra wanted the power. The admission came without ceremony. He wanted the command hidden inside the gold. He wanted a weapon that could force the villages to obey, a shield against any ship that might return, a throne no emissary could strip from him. He wanted to become the god he had pretended to be.

Neferet saw the hesitation. "If you keep it, nothing has changed."

"I could protect Egypt with it."

"You could rule Egypt with it."

"Those are not the same."

"They were not the last time."

The gold light brightened. The broken stone hummed beneath his palm.

Amun-Ra remembered the suspended chains inside the descending city. He remembered the red eye sweeping over the pyramid. He remembered offering the Anunnaki gold, his crown, his life - anything except the truth that he had built their machine with human bodies.

The ship had departed because he had destroyed the beacon. Earth was free, but freedom had not restored the dead. It had only placed the living in front of the ruins.

He lifted the fragment.

The workers recoiled. The overseer reached for his hook.

Amun-Ra carried the gold to the largest remaining slab of the capstone and set it upon the stone. The light spilled across his feet.

"Pharaoh," the scribe whispered, "what are you doing?"

"Ending the beacon."

He raised the royal seal.

The clay tablet struck the gold once. A crack flashed across the surface. He struck again. The golden light burst outward, painting every face in the color of old ambition.

The third blow shattered the fragment.

A sound like a distant star breaking rolled across the desert. The gold collapsed into dull flakes. The brilliant key fractured into countless pieces, each one losing its pulse as it fell. The hum died. The air became ordinary again - hot, gritty, full of human breath.

No one moved.

Then the woman with the sick child stepped forward and crushed a gold flake beneath her heel.

"Good," she said. "Now bury them."

Amun-Ra nodded. "All of them."

The overseer looked toward the pyramid. "There are hundreds beneath the western face."

"Then we open the western face."

"That may bring the stones down."

"It may."

"And if more die?"

Amun-Ra met his eyes. "Then I will stand beneath it with them."

The overseer studied him, searching for the trap hidden beneath the words. At last he turned and shouted for ropes, levers, and water. Workers answered. Their voices did not praise the Pharaoh. They called to one another.

That sound was stranger than any voice from the stars.

By midday, the first bodies emerged. Some were wrapped in torn linen. Some were identified by tools, bracelets, or scars. The scribe wrote each name onto clay tablets until his fingers split. Amun-Ra carried stones beside the workers. The pyramid's blocks cut his shoulders through the linen. Dust filled his mouth. When he stumbled, no one bowed to help him. Neferet seized his arm and pulled him upright with the same roughness she used on everyone else.

"Do not make me carry the Pharaoh too," she said.

"I am no longer wearing the crown."

"That has never stopped a Pharaoh from being a Pharaoh."

He looked at the crown lying in the sand beside the shattered gold. "Then take it."

Neferet glanced at the battered circlet. "What would I do with it?"

"Break it."

She picked it up. For a moment its weight seemed to surprise her. Then she walked to the slab and struck it against the stone.

Lapis shattered. Gold wire sprang loose. The royal scarab split down the middle.

The workers watched in silence.

Amun-Ra felt something inside him break with it - not his authority, because that had already been taken aboard the departing ship, but the private belief that authority was the shape of his soul.

At sunset, the bodies rested beneath fresh earth east of the pyramid. The graves had no grand statues, no incense burners, no promise that the Sky People remembered them. Each bore a clay marker pressed with a name.

Amun-Ra stood among them without sandals. The sand was cool now. Smoke from cooking fires drifted over the burial ground, carrying the smell of onions, ash, and wet clay.

The scribe approached with the first decree.

"Read it," Amun-Ra said.

"By order of Pharaoh Amun-Ra - "

"No."

The scribe lowered the tablet.

"Write: 'By the hands of Egypt.'"

"Who gives the order?"

Amun-Ra looked over the graves, toward the damaged villages and the workers gathering around their fires. "No single voice. The people who carry the stones. The people who plant the grain. The people who bury the dead."

Neferet stood beside him. "And when they disagree?"

"Then I listen until the disagreement has a shape I can serve."

The scribe's eyes widened. "Serve?"

Amun-Ra took the clay tablet from him. With his thumb, he erased the royal scarab before the clay hardened.

"Write it."

The scribe did.

Beyond them, the Great Pyramid rose incomplete against the darkening sky. Without its capstone, it was no longer a road for gods. It was a wound in the desert, enormous and human-made. The alien laser machine lay buried beneath fallen stone, its blue lines extinguished. The black tablet had gone dark. The gold map remained sealed in a clay chamber under guard - not as a promise, but as evidence of the lie.

A child approached carrying a broken piece of gold.

"Pharaoh," he said, "is this treasure?"

Amun-Ra crouched before him. His knees sank into the sand.

"No," he said. "It is a warning."

The child turned the fragment in his fingers. "What will we make from it?"

Amun-Ra looked toward the river, where the first lamps of the villages flickered back to life.

"Tools," he said. "If it can be made into tools. Plow teeth. Needles. Hinges. Nothing that asks a person to kneel."

The child considered this, then handed him the fragment.

Amun-Ra placed it beside the broken crown.

Night settled over the shattered beacon. For the first time, no red light crossed the pyramid's face. No Sky Chariot waited above the clouds. No emissary spoke from the black tablet to measure Egypt's worth in gold.

The silence was not peace yet.

It was space.

Amun-Ra rose and faced the workers. His back ached. His hand burned. He had no crown, no divine promise, and no ship waiting to carry him into eternity.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we open the granaries."

A murmur moved through the camp.

"After that, we repair the wells. Then the homes. Then the fields."

The overseer stepped forward. "And the pyramid?"

Amun-Ra looked up at the broken summit.

"We leave it unfinished."

No thunder answered. No god objected.

Neferet exhaled beside him, almost a laugh, almost grief.

Amun-Ra turned toward the graves and lowered his head - not as a god accepting worship, but as a man standing among the cost of his pride.

Behind him, Egypt began to move.

Not for the stars.

For itself.

About the Author

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Star Gods: Pharaoh Engine

by 12matt3r

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